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THE ELEVENTH
VOXT

VOXT

THE ELEVENTH VOXT

Book Two of The Voxt Chronicles

A Superhero Fantasy Science-Fiction Novel

Written by

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For every city that has never seen a hero.
And for every hero who had to learn what they were protecting
before they could protect it properly.

SYNOPSIS

He saved a world across the stars. Now he has to figure out how to save his own city.

Kael Veyrin — the Eleventh Vox, heir to a cosmic bloodline, the man who called ten ancestral spirits to his side and pushed the Crimson Soul King back into containment — is home. Midway City is the same: the coffee cart on Archer and Fifth, the wobbling chairs, the canal at night with the lights doubling in the water. His sketchbook. His paint. Davan Cross, who has been waiting with a patience that is either genuine friendship or deeply suppressed anxiety, probably both.

Everything is the same. Kael is not.

He has a suit that responds to his energy signature. He can fly. He can form green circular constructs from the air itself. He carries, in the deep register of his awareness, ten predecessor-souls who warm his hands when he paints and steady his resolve when the city needs him. And the city, it turns out, needs him more than he expected — not for cosmic war, not yet, but for the ordinary weight of a place where things go wrong after dark and no one has been there to stop it.

Kael becomes Midway City's first superhero. He is not sure he is doing it right. He is doing it anyway.

But there is a signal. Seraphyne detected it before they landed — something old, something that has been present in Midway City for longer than Malzareth's trackers, something waiting. And beyond Earth, in galaxies that even Aetherion's records have only partial charts for, the Crimson Soul King is doing what he always does when his direct approach fails: he finds another instrument.

His name is Aurelian Voss. He is from a civilization so advanced that the word civilization barely covers it. He is brilliant, elegant, and dressed better than anyone Kael has ever met. His powers manifest in orange-gold light — the ability to conjure things into reality from pure thought, to control weather, to summon, and to construct false realities so complete and so detailed that the people inside them never know they are not real. He has protected his own world for decades. He is, in every sense that matters, exactly the kind of person Kael would want standing beside him.

Malzareth reaches him first.

The corruption shows as red in the orange-gold. It shows in the eyes. And when Aurelian Voss arrives in Midway City — wearing an impeccable suit, enrolling in an art class, carrying the easy confidence of someone who has never walked into a room and not owned it — Kael does not know yet what has been done to him.

He will find out on the worst night the city has ever seen.

THE ELEVENTH VOXT is a story about what happens after the legend. About a young man learning to be a hero in the city that raised him. About the difference between fighting a war and protecting a home. And about the moment when your greatest enemy turns out to be someone who needed saving.

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PROLOGUE

Something Waiting

Somewhere beyond the charted galaxies — Before



The world of Sorveth had no night.

Not because it was always day in the ordinary sense — not because a sun blazed without ceasing — but because Sorveth's people had decided, several centuries ago, that darkness was a management problem, and they had managed it the way they managed every problem: with elegance, with precision, and with technology so refined it had long since become indistinguishable from magic. The sky above Sorveth's cities was a perpetual deep amber at its darkest, shifting through gold and copper as the orbital mechanics of their system changed, always warm, always attended to.

It was a world where things were taken care of.

Aurelian Voss stood on the observation platform of the Sorveth Institute of Cosmological Sciences — which was what the rest of the universe would call a skyscraper, if the rest of the universe had any business making comparisons — and looked out at the amber sky and thought about the report he had just read. He was wearing a suit the color of dark charcoal, cut with the precision of something that had been fitted to his exact measurements and then fitted again, because the first fitting had been very good but the second fitting was perfect. He had been told, many times and by many people, that he dressed better than anyone they had ever met. He accepted this as accurate.

The report was about Earth.

Sorveth's intelligence apparatus had been monitoring Earth for several decades — not with any hostile interest, simply with the professional thoroughness of a civilization that monitored everything — and the report was about an energy signature. A bloodline signal. Something old and cosmic that had recently activated on Earth's surface with a magnitude that their instruments had clocked at levels that were, technically speaking, impossible for a being of biological origin.

Aurelian read the report three times. He turned it over in his mind the way he turned every problem: looking for the load-bearing point, the thing that, if you understood it, made everything else make sense.

Something had awakened on Earth.

He was going to need to go and see.

He did not know, at the time of reading the report, that the Crimson Soul King's attention had also turned toward Earth. He did not know about the signal Seraphyne had detected. He did not know that Malzareth, patient and ancient and vast, had already read the same energy signature and drawn a different conclusion from it.

He did not know that his life was about to change.

He straightened his cuffs. He finished his reading. He went inside.

The amber sky watched him go.

And somewhere in the dark between galaxies, a vast red presence turned, very slowly, toward Sorveth.

PART ONE

Home

CHAPTER ONE

The Painter Returns

Midway City — Three Days After Aetherion



He came back the way he had left: at night, through a portal that closed behind him in an alley in the port district, carrying a bag that was slightly heavier than when he'd packed it because he'd added four sketchbooks filled with drawings of Aetherion that he was going to need months to process properly.

The city smelled like itself. This was the first thing he noticed. Exhaust and concrete and the specific quality of Midway City's night air, which had a mineral undertone that he had never been able to name but that he had been smelling his whole life and which meant, in the most fundamental non-verbal sense possible, home. He stood in the alley and breathed it for a moment.

Seraphyne appeared through the portal behind him, carrying her equipment case. She looked at the alley, assessed it the way she assessed every space — exits, elevation options, ambient threat level — and gave it a brief nod of professional adequacy.

"Holt still hasn't fixed the building entrance light," she said, looking at the street beyond the alley.

"He's been meaning to," Kael said.

"He has been meaning to for four years."

"He is a man of sustained intentions."

They walked to his building. The entrance light was indeed still out. The elevator was still slow. The hallway smelled like Petros's cooking, which was a specific combination of garlic and something herbal that had been part of Kael's olfactory understanding of the concept of home for four years. He stood outside his apartment door for a moment before putting his key in the lock.

Everything on the other side of this door was the same as when he had left it. His easel. His paints in their current state of organized chaos. The green exercise book on the table. The painting of the mountain on the wall that he had done the week before any of this started, before the glowing hands and the flying woman and the stars.

He went in.

He put his bag down. He sat on the edge of his bed.

He looked at his hands. The knuckles glowed, faintly, as they had since arriving back in Earth's atmosphere. Not the suppressed warmth of the dormant power — the easy, present warmth of a power that had been fully activated and was now simply waiting, available, part of him in the way that his hands themselves were part of him.

He was the same person who had sat on this bed three weeks ago and stared at a canvas that had painted itself and wondered what was wrong with him.

He was not the same person at all.

"Kael," Seraphyne said from the doorway. She had the expression she used when she was about to say something she had decided to say simply rather than carefully.

"I know," he said. "Signal. We'll check in the morning."

"The signal hasn't moved."

"Then it'll still be there in the morning." He looked at her. "I need one night. One night of sitting in my own apartment being a person before I start being the Eleventh Voxt again."

She considered this for exactly two seconds — which was Seraphyne's version of a long pause.

"One night," she agreed. She went to set up her monitoring equipment in what he had come to think of as her room, which was technically the utility alcove but which she had, over the years of watching his apartment from the outside, clearly already planned the interior layout of.

He lay back on his bed and looked at the ceiling and listened to Midway City doing its nighttime things through the walls and the windows.

He was home.

He had no idea what came next.

He was, despite everything, glad.



The next morning he stood on the roof.

Not standing on the roof the way you stand on a roof — at the edge, hand on the parapet, looking out. He was hovering approximately one meter above the roof's surface, arms at his sides, facing east, watching the sun come up over Midway City.

He had been doing this for twenty minutes.

The city from above — even from this height, even just one story up from his own rooftop — looked different than from street level. He had always known this abstractly,

the way you know things about perspective from art school. But he had not known it the way he knew it now: with a body that had learned to read space from above, that processed altitude as information rather than as danger.

The city was laid out below him in the early light and it was, objectively, extraordinary. He reached for one of his sketchbooks.

He sketched it hovering. It was the best drawing he had ever done.

CHAPTER TWO

Everything Kael Told Davan



He called Davan at eight in the morning.

"You're back," Davan said, before Kael had said anything.

"I'm back."

"Are you okay?"

"I'm — yeah. I'm okay. Are you free this morning?"

"I moved three client calls for you when you sent that voice note. I have been free for three weeks. I am aggressively free. Where do you want to meet?"

"Can you come here? I don't—" He paused. "I need to show you some things. It'll be easier here than at the coffee cart."

Davan was there in forty minutes. He came through the door and looked at Kael with the careful assessment of a person who has been genuinely worried and is now cataloguing the evidence for whether the worry was justified. He looked at the sketchbooks on the table — four of them, all new, all full. He looked at the suit that Kael had folded over the back of the chair, its dark surface showing the green-violet undertone in the morning light. He looked at Kael's hands.

"You look different," Davan said.

"I am different."

"Good different or complicated different?"

"Both," Kael said. "Sit down."

So he told him. All of it. He had thought about how to do this on the walk to the coffee cart for three weeks across the stars, and he had decided that the right approach was the same one he used when he had a composition that needed explaining: start with the largest shape and work inward. The largest shape was: there is a planet system called Aetherion, there are two energy emperors in a living star, there is a bloodline called the Vox that has been running for ten generations and he is the eleventh. Then the detail: Seraphyne, the night on the canal, flying, the four brothers, his father, the Shrine, the four-hundred-year-old statue of his great-great-great-great-grandmother whose palm he had touched and who had been waiting specifically for him.

Davan listened to all of it. He had the quality — one of his best qualities, Kael had always thought — of listening without rearranging what he heard into the shape of what he expected. He just let it come in.

When Kael finished, Davan was quiet for a moment.

"Show me," he said.

"The suit?"

"Start with the suit. Then show me the thing you can actually do."

Kael put on the suit. In his apartment, in the morning light, the green-violet undertone was very clear. The brushstroke design on the chest caught the light and for a moment looked like it was moving, which it possibly was.

Davan looked at it. "That's an incredible suit," he said. "The chest piece is — is that a brushstroke?"

"I designed it."

"Of course you did." Davan stood up. "Okay. Show me the power."

Kael extended his right hand. A green circular construct formed in the air between them — a ring of solidified energy, about the diameter of a dinner plate, rotating slowly, defined and crisp and very clearly not a trick of the light.

Davan stared at it.

"Touch it," Kael said.

Davan reached out and pressed his fingertips to the edge of the ring. It was solid. Warm. It hummed very faintly at a frequency that was below hearing but present in the chest.

"Okay," Davan said. He sat back down. He was quiet for another moment. "Okay. This explains a lot, actually."

"Does it?"

"The paintings. The glowing. The way you've always looked slightly uncomfortable with the concept of being on the ground for extended periods." He looked at Kael.

"What happens now?"

"Now," Kael said, "I figure out how to protect this city. Because whatever I did in Aetherion — that was the first part of the agreement. The Vext protects both worlds. This is the other one."

Davan looked around the apartment. At the city outside the window. At the suit.

"You're going to need a better public profile than just showing up when things go wrong," he said.

"I know."

"People are going to panic."

"Probably."

"The government is definitely going to try to stop you."

"Almost certainly."

"And you're going to do it anyway."

"Yes."

Davan nodded slowly. "Then I'm in. Whatever you need."

Kael looked at his oldest friend. "Thank you."

"Don't thank me yet," Davan said. "I have a lot of questions about the four brothers and I am going to ask all of them, at length, starting now."

Kael laughed. It was the easiest laugh he'd had in weeks.

CHAPTER THREE

The City at Night



The first time he went out as the Voxt in Midway City, he did not plan to.

It was four in the morning, three days after his return. He could not sleep — his body was still calibrated to Aetherion's slightly longer day cycle, and four AM on Earth felt oddly like late afternoon to some deep part of his physiology. He was on the roof, sketching by the city's ambient light, when he heard it: a car alarm, then shouting, then the specific kind of crash that is not a traffic accident but something being broken through.

He was airborne before he decided to be.

The scene was two blocks east and three floors below: a jewelry store on Harmon Street with its display window caved in, two men moving fast through the gap with bags, and a third watching the street. Ordinary enough, by the statistics of a city this size. The kind of thing that happened and was reported and was occasionally solved and mostly became a number in an annual crime report.

He came down fast, not landing but hovering at street level, his suit's green-violet undertone catching the streetlight.

The lookout saw him first. His mouth opened. No sound came out.

Kael formed a ring-construct — wide, a meter across — and sent it rolling across the sidewalk like a giant coin, where it expanded and settled into a barrier across the broken window just as the first two men turned to run through it. They hit the green

energy wall and bounced back, unharmed but thoroughly stopped, sitting on the jewelry store floor looking up at him with expressions that contained several emotions simultaneously.

"I'm going to need you to stay right there," Kael said.

The lookout ran.

Kael rose, tracked him down the street from the air — not fast, not dramatically, just keeping pace three meters above him at a gentle hover — until the man's running slowed to a jog and then to a walk and then to a stop, at which point he turned around and looked up and said, with remarkable composure for someone who had just been followed by a flying man in a glowing suit: "What are you?"

"Still figuring that out," Kael said honestly. "But for tonight, I'm the reason you're not going home with a bag of other people's property."

He sent a ring-construct to encircle the man's wrists — gently, with enough give that it was not painful, simply firm — and brought him back to the store, where the other two were still sitting in varying states of shock beneath the barrier.

He called the police from a distance and waited until he could hear the sirens before he rose and went back to his roof.

He sat on the rooftop for a long time afterward, heart rate elevated, hands bright green, the city humming around him.

He had just done that. That was a thing he had done.

He opened his sketchbook and drew the street from memory — the broken window, the ring-barrier, the man looking up. He drew it with the specific quality of attention he gave to things he needed to understand, and what he understood, working through the

drawing, was this: the feeling of flying toward a problem with the intention of solving it was not the same as the feeling of flying toward a war. It was smaller and more immediate and somehow more personal. He had not been protecting a world. He had been protecting a store. He had been protecting the people who would have woken up to find their work and their livelihood gone, and the specific weight of that — its ordinariness, its human scale — was not less than the weight of a cosmic battle.

It was different. It was its own thing.

He thought he might be good at it.

He went back inside and finished his sketchbook page and went to bed at five-thirty AM and slept until noon, which was the best sleep he had gotten since before Aetherion.

CHAPTER FOUR

Suit Up



The question of what he was going to call himself was raised by Davan on the fourth day, over coffee at the cart, with the seriousness of a man who had been thinking about it since being told about the suit.

"You need a name," Davan said. "Not Kael Veyrin. A public name. A city name."

"The Voxt," Kael said.

"Is that going to mean anything to anyone here?"

"No."

"Then it's a perfect name," Davan said. "It means something to you and nothing to anyone else until you make it mean something. That's the best kind of name."

Kael thought about this. "The Voxt," he said again.

"The Voxt," Davan confirmed. "Simple. Specific. Slightly intimidating without being theatrical. And when people find out what it means — if they find out — it'll land correctly."

By the end of the first week, Midway City had a name for the figure that had been appearing at the scenes of break-ins, car accidents on the expressway, a warehouse fire in the industrial district that had been moving toward the residential blocks before a wall of green circular constructs redirected it. The name was in the online forums first, then in the Midway City Courier, then on the morning news with footage that was

shaky and under-lit but unmistakable: a figure in a dark suit trailing green light, moving through the air above the city.

The Vext.

The online discourse was, as online discourse tends to be, comprehensive in its range. There were people who were grateful and people who were frightened and people who were both and people who found the whole thing deeply suspicious. There was a dedicated forum thread that had been going for six days about whether the suit was government technology. There was a counter-thread arguing that it was alien in origin, which was correct but which the original thread dismissed as conspiratorial thinking.

Kael read both threads while hovering above the canal with a sketchbook.

He was learning the city from the air. Not the grid of it — he had known the grid since childhood — but the texture. The places where people gathered and the places where they didn't, the rooftops and the access points and the geometry of the industrial district from above, which was completely different from the ground-level experience and which suggested several approaches to rapid transit across the city that he began to map in his sketchbook with the same attention he gave to a canvas: large shapes first, then the detail.

Seraphyne reviewed his city maps every evening.

"Your response time needs to improve on the eastern side," she said on the fifth day.

"The warehouse district is your current blind spot."

"I know. I'm working on a patrol pattern."

"Show me."

He showed her. She moved two lines and adjusted an arc.

"Better," she said.

He updated the map. The city was a painting. You found the composition and you worked it.

CHAPTER FIVE

Learning to Be a Hero



Here is what Kael Veyrin learned in the first two weeks of being Midway City's superhero:

Stopping a crime in progress was easier than he expected. His speed gave him an overwhelming tactical advantage over people who had not accounted for the possibility of someone arriving from directly above. His Conjuring field — the passive energy that extended from his body in all directions and made things cooperate rather than resist — meant that the people he stopped were never hurt by the stopping. The ring-constructs were versatile: barriers, restraints, platforms, shields. He got faster at forming them.

Stopping a crime's causes was harder than he expected. He stopped seventeen burglaries in two weeks. Twelve of them were in the same four blocks of the Caldwell District, which was his own neighborhood, where he had grown up. He had known, abstractly, that his neighborhood had a particular relationship with economic precarity. He had not known it the way he knew it after the twelfth burglary — after talking to Vera about it over the phone, after looking at the faces of the people he was holding in green-energy restraints and recognizing the specific quality of desperation, which is different from greed. He still stopped it. But he thought about it differently afterward.

Flying at speed was intoxicating in a way he had not adequately prepared for. There was a corner of the expressway interchange where, if you came in from the right angle at the right altitude, the crosswinds created a specific kind of lift that was purely physical pleasure — the city dropping away, the speed increasing, the feeling of

absolute freedom that he had felt in the dream before he knew it was a memory. He started going there in the early morning when there was no one to see him, just for the sensation of it. He told Seraphyne this was a patrol pattern.

She knew it was not a patrol pattern. She allowed it because she had read enough Vox medical records to know that the power required exercise that was pleasurable to remain fully functional, and because she was not a monster.

He learned to listen to the city. Not for specific sounds — for the quality of the ambient sound, the way a room's silence has a texture. Midway City at two AM had a sound that was different from three AM which was different from four, and each had a different threat profile and a different emotional register, and he learned them the way he learned a painting's light source: by looking at what the shadows were doing.

He learned that being seen mattered. Not performing — not presenting himself, not making speeches — but being visible. The canal walkway at night, where the attack that had started all this had happened, was now a place where people walked more easily because the word had gotten around that the Voxt patrolled it. He had not announced this. He had simply been there, visible in the air above the water a few nights a week, and the presence had done the work that presence does. He thought about the Vox State. About ten predecessor-spirits surrounding him, visible to everyone. Presence was its own kind of power.

He learned that people wanted to say thank you. This surprised him more than anything. Three separate times in two weeks, someone had found him — not during an intervention, but after, back at his apartment, on the roof, in the alley. Each time he did not know how they had found him. Each time they had something to say. The woman whose convenience store he had stopped two men from robbing brought him food that he ate sitting on the roof with her standing below looking up, and she told him about

her daughter who worked the early shift and what it would have meant if the store had closed. He sat with this.

He told Davan about all of it. Davan listened and asked good questions and occasionally made notes in a small book he had started keeping.

"What are the notes for?" Kael asked once.

"Documentation," Davan said. "The Voxt Chronicles should have a record of this part too."

Kael thought about the Record of the Voxt in the Lyxaran library. The dried-light pages. The blank page at the end.

"You're not wrong," he said.

CHAPTER SIX

The Government Problem



The government had opinions.

More specifically, the City of Midway had opinions, the State had overlapping opinions, and several federal agencies had opinions that were classified and therefore not available to the public but that were aggressively operational, which was more concerning than the city's opinions.

The most immediate opinion arrived in the form of a press conference held by Director Harlan Voss of the Midway City Emergency Management Authority — a compact, precise man in his fifties who had the air of someone who had been managing things for a long time and had opinions about how things should be managed — in which Director Voss described the aerial entity currently operating in Midway City as "an unknown, unaccountable actor" whose activities, however superficially beneficial, represented a regulatory and public safety concern.

Davan watched this press conference at Kael's apartment and said, "He's not wrong."

"He's also not entirely right," Kael said.

"He is correct about the unaccountable part. You are currently unaccountable to anyone in any institutional sense."

"I'm accountable to the city."

"That is a sentiment, not a structure." Davan looked at him. "You need someone on the inside. A contact. Someone who can manage the institutional relationship while you manage the actual work."

The contact came, unexpectedly, from the fourth floor of the Midway City Police Department, in the form of Detective Lena Pryce.

She left a note on his rooftop. He had not told anyone he lived here. The note said: I know who you are. I know what you're doing. I think you're doing the right thing. If you want to talk, there is a coffee cart on Archer and Fifth at six AM on Thursdays that I have been told is worth the trip. I will be there. Come if you want. If you don't come I will not pursue this further.

He came.

Detective Pryce was in her early forties, with the quality of someone whose judgment had been tested enough times that she had stopped doubting it. She had short dark hair and the look of someone who slept adequately when circumstances permitted, which circumstances often did not. She drank black coffee without appearing to think about it, which Kael had always considered a reliable character indicator.

"How did you find where I live?" he asked.

"You're not as subtle as you think when you come and go from the roof," she said. "I've been a detective for fourteen years. I notice rooftop activity."

"Fair enough. What do you want?"

"I want to coordinate," she said. "Not control. Coordinate. There are things I can tell you that help you work better and things you can tell me that help us work better. The city is better with you in it than without you. But the city is also better when what you're doing isn't completely invisible to the people responsible for this place."

Kael looked at her. "And the agencies? The federal ones with the classified opinions?"

"They are going to be a problem regardless. Having an ally inside the department gives you more options when that becomes acute." She wrapped both hands around her mug.

"I'm not asking you to work for the government. I'm asking you to work with one person in it who has decided you're an asset rather than a liability."

He thought about Nyxora's prophecy. The painter who would come at the end of something. The end of something was also the beginning. The Vext had always worked best when they understood the structure of the world they were operating in.

"Thursdays at six," he said. "Same place."

"Same place," said Detective Pryce.

She left first, without ceremony, having gotten what she came for.

Reeves watched her go and then looked at Kael.

"Friend of yours?" Reeves said.

"Getting there," Kael said.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Signal



The signal Seraphyne had detected was in the Caldwell District.

She confirmed this on the fourteenth day, after a week of increasingly precise triangulation using equipment that she had gradually upgraded from the utility alcove into what was now a genuinely impressive monitoring station that occupied most of Kael's kitchen table and required him to eat his meals either on the roof or at Davan's studio.

"It's not moving," she said. "It has not moved since I detected it. It does not appear to be active — it is not broadcasting, not scanning, not engaging. It is present."

"Like it's waiting," Kael said.

"Like it's waiting," she confirmed. "The energy signature is old — older than the Crimson Soul trackers, older than anything I can match to Malzareth's operational profile. It has a quality I have seen in Lyxaran records in a different context."

"What context?"

She looked at him. "The agreements. The ones the Soul Emperors made with Earth's powers before the First Voxt was chosen. The deity Nabu. The cosmic guardians. The forgotten kings of magic." She paused. "This signal has the same frequency quality as those agreements. As though it is a marker left by one of the parties to that original meeting. A marker that is waiting for something specific to happen before it activates."

"The bloodline activating," Kael said.

"That would be my reading. The Voxt arriving on Earth in full power. A signal left, perhaps thousands of years ago, to identify itself when the eleventh generation came home."

They looked at each other.

"We should go find it," he said.

"We should be cautious about going to find it," she said, which was different.

"We should go cautiously find it," he agreed.

The source of the signal was, as best Seraphyne could triangulate, in the basement of a building on Caldwell's eastern edge — a building that, according to the city's public records, had been empty for eleven years and which, according to the building's architectural history, had been on that site in various forms for considerably longer than the city's records went back.

They went at three in the morning, which was when the neighborhood was quietest and the building's lack of activity would draw the least attention. Kael wore the suit.

Seraphyne wore the armor she had brought from Aetherion, which she always wore on operational outings and which had, through some quality of its design, the ability to appear in civilian contexts as a standard-issue dark jacket if you didn't look closely.

Nobody in Midway City ever looked closely at people in dark jackets.

The building's basement, accessible through a door that was locked with a lock that was older than locks should reasonably be in a building this age, held a room. The room held a table. The table held a stone — flat, palm-sized, veined with a material that glowed very faintly in the frequency Seraphyne had detected, a gold-amber warmth that was unmistakably cosmic in origin.

Kael picked it up.

The stone was warm in his hand in the way the Vext statues were warm — the warmth of something conscious, something present, something that had been waiting for exactly this touch.

A voice said, without sound, in the specific register of something that bypassed language and arrived directly as comprehension:

Eleventh of the line. First guardian of this world. You have come home. We have been waiting. There are others coming — one who was like you, from a different star. The Crimson King has touched him. Watch for the orange-gold that bleeds to red. He does not know what has been done. You must reach him before what was done to him becomes permanent. This is what we left the stone for. This is what we asked the Soul Emperors to promise, in the original agreement: that when the darkness turned another guardian against this world, the Vext would be here to see it clearly.

Then the stone was simply a stone. Still warm. Still present. But finished saying what it had been left to say.

Kael stood in the basement room for a long time, holding it.

"Orange-gold that bleeds to red," he said.

"Someone is coming," Seraphyne said. Her voice was very careful. "Someone powerful. Someone who does not know they have been corrupted."

"Someone who was like me," Kael said. "From a different star."

He put the stone in his jacket pocket.

"How long do we have?" he asked.

"The stone didn't say," she said.

"No," he said. "It wouldn't."

He looked at the empty room. At the table. At the very old door.

"Then we'd better keep working," he said. "And keep watching."

PART TWO

Aurelian

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Man in the Suit

Midway City — Week Three



He arrived on a Tuesday.

Kael did not know this at the time. He found out later, the way you find out the exact date of important things that happened before you knew they were important. What he knew on Tuesday was that it was the kind of Tuesday that Midway City does in late autumn: grey at the edges, bright in the middle where the sun had found a gap in the cloud cover, the canal catching the light in that specific way it had when the sky was doing something interesting.

Aurelian Voss stepped out of a portal — not a Ring Gate, not the Aetherion kind, but a different kind, one that opened like a fold in the air rather than a window, and which closed behind him with a sound like a held breath released — and stood on the corner of Archer and Fifth at eight-fifteen AM and looked at Midway City.

He was wearing a charcoal suit with a thread count that was not available at any tailor in the city. His shoes were the color of dark amber and had been polished to a standard that was not aggressive but was absolute. He had the bearing of someone who had walked into many different cities on many different worlds and had found all of them, in one way or another, interesting. He was perhaps thirty-five, dark-skinned with a warmth to his complexion that did not correspond to any Earth geographic region, with close-cut hair and the kind of face that was not conventionally handsome so much as

structurally compelling — the kind of face that made you want to keep looking because there seemed to be more there than you'd initially registered.

He looked at the coffee cart.

He looked at the city.

He looked at the coffee cart again.

He walked to the cart, ordered something from Reeves that Reeves had to think about for thirty seconds before confirming he could make, and stood with his coffee looking at the street with the expression of someone who is collecting information and finding it satisfactory.

He had been doing this — arriving, assessing, collecting — on seventeen worlds in the last six months. He was thorough. He was patient. He dressed impeccably at all times because he had found, across many cultures and civilizations, that looking well-assembled communicated things that were useful to communicate.

He was looking for the energy signature. The bloodline signal. The thing that had brought him here.

What he found instead, when he looked up from his coffee at the right moment at the right angle, was a figure at the edge of his peripheral vision — moving across the grey sky between two buildings, green-lit at the edges, moving with the specific quality of something that was flying rather than falling.

His coffee paused halfway to his mouth.

He watched the green light disappear behind a rooftop.

He looked down at his hands.

His knuckles were the color of orange-gold — the warmth of his own power, his own Sorveth inheritance, the ability that had been with him since before he knew what it was.

He closed his hands. The color faded.

"Interesting," he said, to no one in particular.

Reeves, who had heard stranger things said at his cart, said nothing.



Aurelian Voss had been, on his home world of Sorveth, many things in sequence: a student of cosmological engineering, a field researcher, a guardian. The guardian part was the most recent and the most significant. Sorveth's governing council had, upon discovering that one of their citizens had manifested abilities of a scale that the civilization's risk assessment protocols classified as "requires institutional management," decided to manage it institutionally.

The management had been, by all objective measures, excellent. He had a title, a liaison, a budget, and access to the Institute's full research apparatus. He had also, in the twelve years since his powers had fully manifested, used those powers to prevent four extinction-level events across three solar systems, stabilize a collapsing star that had been nine hours from a supernova, and on one occasion — a story he did not tell in professional contexts — negotiate a peace between two civilizations whose conflict had been running for four hundred years by constructing, in the shared space between their territories, a physical reality so persuasively neutral and beautiful that both sides had sat down in it to talk before they realized what they were doing.

That last one had been his favorite.

He had the ability to conjure things into reality — not illusions, not simulations, but actual physical objects and environments drawn from his imagination and made real by his energy. Orange-gold light was the color of the conjuring: warm, vivid, unmistakable. He could control weather, summon across distances, call specific objects or people from one location to another. And his most extraordinary ability — the one that had made the peace negotiation possible — was the construction of false realities. Not deceptions: complete experiential environments, fully physical, fully sensory, that the people within them experienced as real because they were real, for the duration of the conjuring. He could make anywhere into somewhere else. He could make something that did not exist as real as something that did.

He was, by any reasonable measure, extraordinary.

He was also, at this specific moment in his life, being very slowly and very thoroughly corrupted by a consciousness so vast and so patient that he had not noticed it happening.

He would not notice for some time yet.

He finished his coffee, thanked Reeves with the politeness of someone for whom politeness was a genuine value rather than a performance, and went to find a hotel. He had business in Midway City. He was going to take his time doing it properly.

CHAPTER NINE

Art Class



The art class was Davan's idea.

"You need to be a person," Davan said, on the seventeenth day. "Not just the Vext. You need Kael Veyrin to have a life, or Kael Veyrin is going to disappear into the Vext and then who does the painting?"

"I paint all the time."

"You paint on rooftops at two in the morning while hovering slightly above the surface. That is not the same as having a life." He put a flyer on the table. "The Caldwell Community Arts Center has a new session starting. Tuesday evenings. Mixed media. I signed us both up."

Kael looked at the flyer. "You signed me up for an art class."

"You are an artist. It is an art class. The logic is not complicated."

"I went to art school, Davan."

"And now you are a cosmic superhero who paints in isolation and doesn't talk to anyone except me and a detective and a military commander from another planet. The class is good for you. It has humans in it."

He could not argue with this. He went.

The Caldwell Community Arts Center occupied the ground floor of a building on Fourth Street that had been a hardware store and before that a laundry and before that

something the building's oldest residents described vaguely as "a different kind of place" without elaborating. It smelled like fresh paint and the particular slightly-sweet smell of new canvas and wood shavings from the stretcher-making station in the back. The instructor was a woman named Marguerite who had the energy of someone who had been teaching art for long enough to have strong opinions about everything and the wisdom to share them selectively.

There were twelve students in the class. Kael and Davan arrived together and took spots at adjacent easels.

The man at the easel to Kael's right arrived four minutes late.

He came through the door with the ease of someone who is never truly late because they make the room adjust to them rather than the other way around, wearing a dark charcoal suit with no visible concession to the fact that he was about to paint in it, and he looked at the available easels and chose the one beside Kael with the same decisive quality he applied to all choices.

"Sorry," he said, to the room generally. "I had difficulty finding parking." He said this with a slight warmth in his voice that suggested he was aware the excuse was thin but found the thinness of it mildly amusing. He set up his materials — which were, Kael noticed, considerably nicer than anyone else's — with practiced efficiency.

He looked at Kael. "I'm Aurelian," he said.

"Kael."

"What are you working on?" He nodded at the blank canvas.

"Not sure yet. I usually wait to see what comes."

Aurelian considered this. "I find that approach either very brave or very dangerous depending on the day," he said. "Today looks like it might be both."

He turned to his own canvas and began to sketch, and even in the preliminary sketch — in the quality of the line, the consideration of the composition — Kael could see that this was not a beginner. This was someone who had been looking at the world carefully for a long time and had strong ideas about how to represent what they saw.

Davan, from the other side, caught Kael's eye. Raised an eyebrow.

Kael gave a small shrug. New person. Seems fine.

He turned back to his own canvas and started to paint.

An hour later, Aurelian leaned slightly sideways to look at what Kael had produced. It was Aetherion — he had not meant to paint Aetherion, he had been trying to paint the canal, but the composition had drifted, as his compositions did, toward the thing behind the thing. The four planets. The Weave Rings. The Core at the center, green-violet and alive.

"That's extraordinary," Aurelian said. His voice had changed — the easy social warmth was still there but underneath it something had sharpened, the way a person's attention sharpens when they see something they recognize.

"Thank you," Kael said. "What are you painting?"

Aurelian's canvas showed a sky. A specific sky — amber at the darkest, shifting through gold and copper. Not an Earth sky. Not a sky from any place Kael had seen in his sketchbooks of Aetherion.

"Home," Aurelian said simply.

Kael looked at the painting.

He looked at Aurelian.

He did not know yet. But something in him — the Conjuring instinct, the ability to see the thing behind the thing — filed the moment carefully.

CHAPTER TEN

Orange-Gold



Aurelian Voss enrolled in the art class for Tuesdays and stayed in Midway City through Wednesday and Thursday and then through the following week entirely, at which point he stopped pretending he was going to leave soon and booked a long-term rate at the Caldwell Arms hotel, which was not the most expensive hotel in the city but was close enough to the arts center and the coffee cart that the geography made sense.

He appeared at the coffee cart on Thursday morning. Kael was already there. They did not arrange this. It was simply what happened when two people are operating in the same small geography at the same time of day.

"You paint this city from memory," Aurelian said, looking at the sketchbook Kael had open on the cart's narrow counter. "Even when you try to paint something else."

"It comes out anyway," Kael said.

"I understand that." Aurelian looked at his own coffee. "Where I'm from, we call it the pull. The thing your perception keeps returning to regardless of what you direct it toward. The thing that is, for you, the most interesting thing in any room."

"What's yours?" Kael asked.

Aurelian was quiet for a moment. "Systems," he said. "The way things connect. The way a city is not just buildings but the space between buildings. The way a civilization is not just its institutions but the assumptions underneath the institutions." He smiled.

"Abstract, I know. Less painterly than your planets."

"My planets are a system," Kael said.

"Yes," said Aurelian. "That's interesting, isn't it."

They drank their coffee. The city moved around them.

"What brings you to Midway City?" Kael asked.

"Research," Aurelian said. "I study energy signatures. Cosmological signals." He looked at Kael with an evenness that might have been openness or might have been something more deliberate. "There was a signal here recently. Significant enough that I needed to see it in person."

The warmth in Kael's hands increased very slightly.

"Find what you were looking for?" he said, with the careful neutrality of someone who does not yet know how much to say.

"I think so," Aurelian said. "Though the finding raises new questions, as findings tend to."

He finished his coffee, thanked Reeves, and left — walking, not through any visible transit method, simply down Archer in the direction of the hotel. Kael watched him go.

He took out his sketchbook and drew the man from memory: the charcoal suit, the particular way he held his coffee, the quality of his attention when it sharpened. He drew his hands and tried to capture something about the quality of the light around them, which he had noticed in the art class — a faint amber warmth at the edges of the fingers, barely perceptible, the kind of thing you would dismiss as a trick of the light if you were not someone whose hands also did things like that.

He drew a question mark next to the sketch.

Then he called Seraphyne.

"There's a man," he said. "In the art class. He's from somewhere that is not Earth. And his hands do something."

There was a pause on Seraphyne's end.

"Describe the something," she said.

"Amber. Orange-gold. Warm at the edges when he's paying close attention to something."

Another pause. Longer.

"The signal from the stone," she said.

"Orange-gold that bleeds to red," Kael said.

"Yes." Her voice was very careful. "I need to run some scans. Don't do anything yet."

"I'm not doing anything," Kael said. "I'm drinking coffee and drawing in my sketchbook."

"That is, for you, effectively nothing," she agreed. "Keep doing nothing. I will call you when I have something."

CHAPTER ELEVEN

What Seraphyne Found



She found him in four hours.

Not Aurelian specifically — she found his world. Sorveth. It was in the Lyxaran archives, in the section she described as "civilizations at the edge of the system's detection range" — worlds that were known to Aetherion's scholars but not well-documented, far enough from the Zytherak and Aetherion systems that the information was partial and dated.

What the archives had on Sorveth was enough.

She sat Kael down at the kitchen-table monitoring station and walked him through it. Sorveth: a world several thousand years more technologically advanced than Earth, a world that had solved most of the problems that occupied Earth's political and social energies and had moved on to larger questions. A civilization that monitored the cosmos with thoroughness. A world that had, approximately twelve years ago by their own calendar, registered a citizen who had manifested abilities of a scale that their instruments classified as cosmologically significant.

"Aurelian Voss," Kael said.

"The Lyxaran archives don't have a name. But the energy profile description matches. Conjuring-class abilities. Weather manipulation. Summoning. And—" She paused at the screen. "Reality construction. The ability to build physical environments from imagination. This is rare. In Aetherion's records of cosmological beings, there are perhaps four documented cases in the last three thousand years."

"He's powerful," Kael said.

"He is extraordinarily powerful," Seraphyne said. "If Malzareth has been able to corrupt someone of this capability level, the threat is not theoretical."

"Does the Lyxaran archive say anything about corruption risk?"

"The archive says that beings with reality-construction ability are specifically vulnerable to soul-infection of Malzareth's type," she said. "Because the infection doesn't need to overwhelm their will directly — it works through the construction ability itself. It introduces a corruption into the conjuring, making the things they construct carry the infection's frequency. Everything they build becomes a vector." She looked at him. "If he builds a reality around this city while corrupted, everyone in that reality is potentially exposed."

Kael thought about the art class. Aurelian's painting of the amber sky. The quality of his attention. The warmth at the edges of his fingers.

"He doesn't know," Kael said.

"The stone said he doesn't know," Seraphyne confirmed. "Soul-infection at this stage is typically pre-conscious. The infected person experiences increased capability, increased confidence, a slight narrowing of their ethical peripheral vision — a growing certainty that what they are doing is right, regardless of what they are doing. It feels like clarity."

"It feels like clarity," Kael repeated. "And underneath it, the corruption is building. Getting ready."

"Until it is complete. And then the person who was there — the person who was genuinely brilliant and genuinely good — is directed toward a purpose that is not their own."

Kael looked at the window. At the city outside.

"How do we stop it?" he said.

"The Voxt Conjuring field introduces clear signal," Seraphyne said. "It worked on the soul-infected soldiers. It worked on Malzareth himself, at scale. But this is different — this is not a person whose will has already been overwritten. This is a person mid-process. The corruption is not complete." She paused. "Which means if you reach him clearly, deeply enough, before it is complete — you might be able to give him back to himself."

"Or?" Kael said.

"Or," she said carefully, "the corruption completes before you get there, and you face someone with reality-construction ability fully directed against this city, by a consciousness that wants it destroyed."

They were quiet for a moment.

"Okay," Kael said. "What do I do right now?"

"Right now?" Seraphyne said. "You go back to art class on Tuesday. You get to know him. You watch. You wait for the moment when you can reach him clearly — and when that moment comes, you take it immediately."

"And in the meantime?"

"In the meantime," she said, "you protect this city. Because Malzareth's plan is not Aurelian alone. Aurelian is the instrument. The attack — when it comes — will be designed to use his specific abilities against a specific place." She looked at the map of Midway City on her monitoring screen. "This specific place."

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Corruption

Somewhere beyond charted space — Simultaneously



Malzareth did not think in the way that individuals think.

He was too old for that. He was too large. Individual thought — sequential, bounded, personal — was a mode he had passed through so far back in his history that it was no longer accessible as a lived experience, only as an observed phenomenon in the beings around him. He understood individual thought the way a river understands the shape of a stone it has worn smooth: it knew the stone's contours by the specific way the water had to move around them, but the stone was not something the river experienced. The stone was something the river worked.

Aurelian Voss was a stone he was working.

The contact had been made six months ago, in the space between Sorveth and the first of the seventeen worlds Aurelian had visited on his research journey. A moment of transition — always the most permeable moment, always the moment when the edges of a person's awareness are occupied with the logistics of movement and the essential center of the self is briefly, infinitesimally accessible. Malzareth had not introduced anything dramatic. He never did. He had introduced a feeling.

The feeling was this: certainty. The specific quality of certainty that feels like finally. As though something that had been slightly unresolved — a low-grade question that had been running in the background of a very organized mind — had been answered. As though a direction that had been approximately right had become precisely right.

Aurelian had felt it as clarity. As the sensation of knowing what he was doing and why, with a completeness that had not previously been available to him.

He had been a good person before Malzareth touched him. He remained, technically, a good person — his values were intact, his care for the worlds he encountered was genuine, his curiosity was real. The corruption worked not by replacing these things but by redirecting them. By making the destination of all that genuine goodness, all that genuine capability, a target that served a purpose other than its own.

The target was Earth.

The method was what Malzareth had always used: find the person with the most power, find the angle at which that power could be aimed, and wait. Wait with the absolute patience of something that has existed since before the concept of patience was invented. Wait with the serene certainty of an inevitable thing.

Aurelian Voss, walking the streets of Midway City in his impeccable suit, looking at the city with the researcher's interested gaze, drinking good coffee and attending an art class and painting the amber sky of his home world from memory, was moving, without knowing it, toward the moment when the certainty would become action.

Malzareth waited.

He was very good at waiting.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Friends of the City



The weeks that followed had a quality that Kael would remember afterward as the best and strangest period of his life.

Strange because he was simultaneously being a superhero — stopping a building collapse in the warehouse district that made the morning news for three days, intervening in a situation at the Caldwell overpass that Detective Pryce had tipped him about forty minutes in advance, managing an increasingly complex patrol pattern that now covered four of the city's seven districts — and living his life. His actual life, with its actual textures. Tuesday art class. Thursday coffee with Detective Pryce. The occasional evening at Davan's studio where they argued about painting and drank tea and Davan showed him the documentation he was building of the Vost's activities in Midway City, which was meticulous and dry and genuinely useful.

And Aurelian.

Aurelian Voss was, setting aside everything Kael knew and feared and watched for, one of the most interesting people he had ever met.

He was perceptive in the way that very intelligent people are perceptive — not just noticing things but connecting them, finding the structural relationship between observations that most people kept in separate categories. He had been to more places than Kael had, though their respective definitions of "place" were extremely different and the comparison required some negotiation. He had opinions about art that were informed and occasionally infuriating. He was funny in the dry, sidelong way of

someone who finds the world genuinely amusing rather than performing amusement for effect.

And he was, Kael noticed, increasingly watching him.

Not suspiciously. Not with the directed attention of someone who knew what Kael was. But with the quality of someone who had identified something in his vicinity that was interesting and had not yet determined exactly what it was. The same quality, Kael realized, that he himself had noticed in Aurelian at the coffee cart on that first Thursday.

Two people who knew that the other one was something more than they appeared, neither one yet ready to say it.

In the art class on the third Tuesday, Aurelian looked at Kael's canvas for a long moment. Kael had painted Seraphyne — not in armor, not as a Commander, but the way he had first seen her in his apartment doorway: precise, present, with the scar at the corner of her eyebrow and the quality of someone who has decided where all the exits are.

"You paint real people," Aurelian observed.

"I paint what I know," Kael said.

"Who is she?"

"Someone who watches out for me," Kael said. "Has done for a long time."

Aurelian nodded. He looked at his own canvas. He was painting systems today — the city's street grid, from above, which meant he had accessed some aerial perspective that was not available from street level. Kael said nothing about this.

"I had someone like that," Aurelian said. "On Sorveth. A liaison. Someone whose job was to watch out for me while I watched out for everyone else." He paused. "I miss her. It's strange, being somewhere without — infrastructure. Without the institutional framework."

"You get used to it," Kael said.

"Do you?" Aurelian looked at him. "Or do you just get better at working within the limits of it?"

Kael thought about Detective Pryce. About Seraphyne in the utility alcove. About Davan's documentation notebook. About his father, three stars away, recovering in a Lyxaran medical facility.

"Both," he said. "Probably."

They painted in comfortable silence for a while.

Outside, Midway City went about its day. Ordinary and extraordinary simultaneously, the way cities always are.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

What Malzareth Did

Four Weeks After Kael's Return



It happened on a Wednesday night.

Kael was on patrol — the eastern arc, over the warehouse district that Seraphyne had identified as his coverage gap, moving at moderate speed through the orange-grey sky of the industrial corridor — when he felt it. Not heard, not saw, not registered through any of the usual senses.

Felt.

The same way he had felt the Weave Ring disruption in Aetherion. The same way he had felt the Shrine of Stone under attack. A structural change in something that had previously been stable. A quality of something that had been building for weeks reaching a threshold.

He turned east and accelerated.

The source of the feeling was the Caldwell Arms hotel. He arrived at altitude above it within four seconds and hovered, looking down, his Conjuring field extended to maximum range.

The hotel room on the ninth floor.

Inside it, Aurelian Voss sat on the edge of the bed in his undone suit jacket, his hands on his knees, and his hands were wrong. The orange-gold was still there — still present, still his — but at the very edges, at the fingertips, the warmth had turned a shade that

was not amber but something colder. Something that was amber the way fire is sometimes amber before it turns to something that burns differently.

Red.

Just at the edges. Just beginning.

Kael hovered above the hotel and thought very fast. The stone had said: you must reach him before what was done to him becomes permanent. Seraphyne had said: if you reach him clearly, deeply enough, before it is complete, you might be able to give him back to himself.

The tips of Aurelian's fingers were red.

This was the moment.

Kael descended to the ninth floor window and knocked on it.

There was a pause from inside. Then the window opened.

Aurelian looked at him. He looked at the suit. He looked at the green glow at the edges of Kael's hands. His expression did several things in quick succession — recognition, surprise, something that was either anger or fear or the precursor to both — and then settled into the specific stillness of someone who has just had a large quantity of things confirmed simultaneously.

"You're the Vext," he said.

"And you're from Sorveth," Kael said.

A pause.

"You should come in," Aurelian said.

He came in.

They sat — Aurelian on the edge of the bed, Kael in the chair — and they told each other the truth. Not all of it immediately, and not without the specific caution of two people who have been carrying secrets and are assessing how much trust the moment supports. But enough. Aurelian told him about Sorveth, about his abilities, about the research journey. Kael told him about the Vext, about Aetherion, about the stone in the basement.

"The stone said someone was coming," Kael said. "Someone who was like me, from a different star. Someone who had been touched by the Crimson Soul King."

Aurelian was very still.

"I haven't felt different," he said. His voice was level. The voice of someone who is assessing rather than reacting.

"I know," Kael said. "That's the thing about how it works. It doesn't feel different. It feels like clarity." He paused. "Your hands."

Aurelian looked down. At his hands. At the amber-orange warmth. At the very edges of his fingertips, where the color was not quite right.

The stillness in his face changed.

"How long?" he said.

"I don't know. Long enough that it's started to show. Not so long that it's finished."

"Can it be reversed?"

"I think so," Kael said. "I've done it before, at scale. But not on someone mid-process. Not like this."

Aurelian looked at his hands for a long time.

"What do I feel when it gets close to complete?" he said. "What will I feel differently?"

"According to everything I know," Kael said honestly, "nothing. You will feel the same clarity. The same certainty. But what you will be certain about —"

"Will be what he wants," Aurelian finished.

"Yes."

Another pause. Very long.

"Then we need to move quickly," Aurelian said. He straightened his jacket. He did this automatically, Kael noticed — the gesture of a person who thinks clearly when composed and who had learned to use small acts of composure as tools. "What do you need from me?"

"Right now?" Kael said. "Nothing. I need to prepare. And I need you to tell me immediately — the moment anything feels different. The moment the certainty about anything shifts."

"And if I can't tell?"

"Then I'll be watching," Kael said. "Close enough to know before you do."

Aurelian nodded.

He looked at his hands one more time.

"I have protected seventeen worlds," he said, quietly. "I have never been the threat."

"You're not the threat," Kael said. "What was done to you is. There's a difference." He stood up. "And we're going to take it back."

He went back to the window. He looked at the city.

"By the way," Aurelian said. "Your suit is very good."

"Yours is better," Kael said honestly.

For the first time since the conversation started, Aurelian Voss smiled.

PART THREE

The Night Midway Went Dark

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Storm Begins

Five Weeks After Kael's Return — A Friday Night



It started with the weather.

Midway City did not have the kind of weather that started like this. It had ordinary weather — the grey autumns Kael had grown up with, the occasional storm that came in from the lake to the northwest, the specific quality of the city's winter which was cold without being dramatic. It did not have weather that arrived without meteorological precedent in the span of eleven minutes and turned a clear November night into something that felt like the end of a different kind of world.

The clouds came first. Not gathering — appearing. Full, dark, charged with something that was not atmospheric electricity but had the same quality, the same hair-raising promise of something about to discharge. They covered the entire city in nine minutes. The temperature dropped eight degrees in the remaining two.

Then the lightning.

But not natural lightning. The color was wrong. Natural lightning is white-blue, brilliant and brief. This was amber. Orange-gold, precise, striking the same five points on the city's skyline in a pattern that was not random — that had the quality of something considered, something chosen, something that was establishing coordinates rather than discharging energy.

Kael was on the roof when it started. He was airborne in four seconds.

He rose above the cloud layer — an act that required speed and certainty through the transition, the clouds dense and electric around him for the three seconds of ascent — and hovered above it, looking down at the orange-gold lightning moving through the city below, and he knew.

He called Seraphyne from the air.

"I see it," she said. She was already at the monitoring station. "The energy signature is Aurelian's. It is — Kael, it has completed. The corruption index is at full saturation. He has no—" Her voice tightened. "He will have no awareness of it. He will believe everything he is doing is right."

"Where is he?"

She gave him the coordinates. He dropped through the clouds and flew.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

False Realities



Aurelian Voss stood at the center of Caldwell District's main intersection and he was magnificent.

That was the terrible thing about it. He was not monstrous. He was not diminished. He stood in the orange-gold light that was rising from him like a second atmosphere, his suit still impeccable — the corruption did not touch the aesthetics, apparently — and he was fully, completely himself. Brilliant. Precise. Confident in the specific way of someone who believes, without any doubt whatsoever, that what they are doing is exactly right.

The reality construction had already started.

It was subtle at the edges of the intersection — the buildings were still themselves, but the air between them had changed texture, had the quality of something slightly more vivid than reality usually is, slightly more resolved. Kael had read about this in Seraphyne's briefings. The false reality being built over the existing one, layer by layer, until the constructed reality was what people experienced and the actual reality was inaccessible beneath it.

People in the street were stopping and looking around with the expression of people who feel that something has changed but cannot identify what. Which was accurate. Something had changed. Their sensory reality was being very gently, very expertly redirected.

Kael landed at the intersection's edge.

"Aurelian," he said.

Aurelian turned. His eyes were amber at the center and red at the rim — the corruption fully expressed, the orange-gold of his own power and the Crimson Soul King's direction occupying the same space, indistinguishable from inside.

"Kael," he said. His voice was warm. Genuinely warm. He sounded like himself. "You should stand back. This is going to be—"

"What you're doing to this city," Kael said, "is not what you think it is."

"I'm protecting it," Aurelian said, with the serene certainty of a man who has never been more sure of anything. "The threat to this world is real. I can see it clearly. I can see exactly what needs to be done."

"I know that's what it feels like," Kael said. "That's what it always feels like."

Something flickered in Aurelian's eyes. Not doubt — the corruption did not permit doubt. But recognition, perhaps. The memory of a conversation in a hotel room.

Then the reality construction sharpened around them, and the flickering was gone.

"Stand back," Aurelian said again. Kindly. Genuinely. "Please."

"No," Kael said.

And then the false reality closed around the intersection like a hand closing around water, and the night above them went from the orange-gold lightning to something else entirely — a sky Kael had never seen, warm amber at the darkest, shifting through gold and copper, the sky above Sorveth, rendered with the loving precision of someone painting home from memory.

The people in the street stopped looking confused. They stopped looking like anything. They were inside the false reality now and the false reality, unlike the corrupted purpose beneath it, was genuinely beautiful — Aurelian Voss could not make ugly things, even now. The constructed world around them was extraordinary.

It was also, if it completed, going to be a vector for Malzareth's infection across an entire city block's worth of civilians.

Kael looked at the amber sky of Sorveth above him.

He looked at Aurelian.

"Let's take this somewhere else," he said.

He rose into the air, extending his hand.

The invitation.

Aurelian looked at the extended hand. He rose to meet him.

The battle left the ground.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Punch for Punch



They fought above the city.

There was no other way to say it that did justice to what it was: two beings of extraordinary capability, moving through the sky above Midway City at speeds that the surveillance cameras below would later capture only as streaks of light — green and orange-gold, crossing and recrossing, the orange-gold in the east and the green in the west and then neither of them anywhere and then both of them in the same place for a moment that lasted less than a second and left the air charged in the specific way of things that have been moved through very quickly.

Aurelian fought with his construction ability. He conjured things into the air between them — not to harm, not yet, the corruption had not yet directed his power toward violence, but to contain, to redirect, to build the constructed reality around Kael the way you might build a room around a person to slow them down. A wall here, a floor there, a structure that redirected his flight path and tried to bring him into the false reality's grip.

Kael dismantled the constructions the way he dismantled everything: by finding the handle. The constructs had a nature — orange-gold energy given form, directed by a will that was currently not entirely its own. He felt for the load-bearing point of each construction and Conjured it into cooperation, finding the handle and asking the construct to resolve back into what it was before Aurelian made it into what it was.

The constructs dissolved around him. Aurelian made new ones.

There was something extraordinary, in the middle of all of it, about watching Aurelian work. Even corrupted, even operating under a direction that was not his own, the construction ability was luminous. He built things the way Kael painted — with the specific attention of someone who sees the thing behind the thing and renders not the surface but the essence. The constructs were not just walls and barriers: they were beautiful. The Sorveth sky that he kept rebuilding overhead was genuinely magnificent.

Kael noticed this. He filed it.

The fight moved across the city. Above the canal — where Aurelian built a construct over the water that made the canal briefly, impossibly, reflect the amber sky of Sorveth instead of Midway City's clouded orange-grey. Above the warehouse district, where a particularly large construct formed and Kael dismantled it with a ring-construct the diameter of the warehouse itself, rolling through the air like a wheel. Above the expressway interchange where Kael had been doing his early-morning speed runs, which felt like a different life now.

Punch for punch. Construction for Conjuring. Orange-gold meeting green in the night sky above a city that had not asked for any of this and was experiencing it anyway, the way cities experience things: all at once, with the whole of itself, leaving marks that take a long time to read.

And Kael talked.

Through all of it, between the constructs and the Conjurations and the aerial exchanges that left his ribs aching from two hard hits and his hands blazing green and his vision narrowed with the effort of it — through all of it, he talked.

"You painted Sorveth in the art class," he said, pulling right to avoid a construct that sealed the space in front of him. "From memory. You painted home."

"Do not," Aurelian said, and he sounded, briefly, strained.

"The amber sky. You painted it the same way I paint Aetherion. Because it was there when you closed your eyes. Because it was the thing behind the thing."

A construct formed around Kael's right side. He dissolved it.

"The liaison you told me about," Kael said. "The one you miss. What was her name?"

A pause. In the pause, a construct that should have been immediate was two seconds late.

"Don't," Aurelian said again. Louder this time. Strained.

"I'm not trying to hurt you," Kael said. "I'm trying to remind you."

He did not stop fighting. He kept the pressure on — kept the ring-constructs forming, kept the dismantling active, kept Aurelian in the kind of engaged response that didn't allow the false reality to stabilize and spread. But he kept talking. Kept naming the things he knew. The art class. The coffee cart. The painting of systems. Sorveth's amber sky. The quality of his attention when something interested him. The way he straightened his jacket when he needed to think clearly.

Aurelian's constructions were getting slower.

Not weaker — slower. The amber-gold light around him was still brilliant. But the red at the rim of his eyes was, in moments between constructions, slightly less saturated.

"You are the most extraordinary painter I have met on seventeen worlds," Aurelian said, from ten meters above him, and his voice was the voice of someone fighting two things at once: an opponent and themselves. "I have not told you that."

"Thank you," Kael said. "You are the most extraordinary builder I have met in eleven generations."

Something in Aurelian's face broke open.

Just for a moment. Just at the edges.

Kael took the moment.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The City Falls



But the moment was not enough.

Not yet.

The corruption surged — Malzareth, sensing the threat to his hold, asserting it with the full patience-powered certainty of something that has been building for a very long time and will not be undone by sentiment. The red flooded back into Aurelian's eyes completely. The amber-gold constructions multiplied: not just around Kael, not just above the city, but across the entire city, the false reality expanding from the intersection where it had started, spreading block by block with the precision of someone who understood systems.

Because that was Aurelian's pull. Systems. He was building not just a false reality but a systemic false reality — one that spread through the city's infrastructure, its power grid, its communication lines, its sensory environment. Every screen in Midway City went the color of the Sorveth sky. Every surface that could catch light caught the amber-gold of Sorveth's perpetual warmth. The city was being repainted from the inside, and the paint was Malzareth's.

On the ground, Seraphyne's comm was going. "Kael. The infection vector is activating across the construction. I'm reading Crimson Soul frequency in the false reality's energy. If this completes — if the construction reaches the city's outer limits — we have a full infection event."

"How long?" Kael said.

"Twenty minutes. Maybe fifteen."

Detective Pryce's voice on a different channel: "Vox. I have reports coming in from every district. What is happening?"

"Working on it," Kael said.

"That is not an answer."

"I know. I'll explain after." He cut the channel and rose higher.

Below him, Midway City was going dark. Not the lights — the lights were on, all of them, bathed in amber-gold. Dark in the sense that the city's essential quality, the thing that made it itself, was being covered over. Its specific grey autumns, its canal with the lights doubling in the water, its rooftops where a painter could hover and sketch, its coffee cart where Reeves served bad decaf with undiminished personal conviction — all of it still there, physically, but overlaid with something that was not it.

Kael looked at the city going dark beneath him.

He looked at Aurelian, hovering fifty meters away, the corruption in full control, building with the absolute focused efficiency of a brilliant person who has been given a clear direction and no reason to doubt it.

He looked at his hands.

The warmth in them was very high. Ten predecessor-souls, present at the deep register of his awareness, warm and patient and waiting.

He thought about lying on the ground in Theronis with two cracked ribs, looking up at the burning sky, and laughing.

He looked at the amber sky that Aurelian had built over his city.

He looked at Aurelian building it.

A man who missed his home. A man who painted the amber sky from memory because it was the thing behind every thing. A man who had protected seventeen worlds and had never been the threat and who did not know, right now, that he was the threat, because the corruption felt like clarity and clarity felt like purpose and purpose felt like everything he had always wanted to do.

Kael rose until they were level.

He did not reach for a construct. He did not engage the Conjuring in the battle sense.

He spoke.

"Aurelian," he said. Not loudly. Not urgently. With the quality of someone who is saying a name and meaning the whole person that name has ever been. "I need you to look at the sky."

"I built that sky," Aurelian said. The red in his eyes was absolute.

"I know," Kael said. "Look at it."

A pause. Aurelian looked up at the amber sky he had built over Midway City.

"It's Sorveth," he said.

"Yes."

"I built it here."

"Yes. Why?"

A longer pause. The city going amber below them. Fifteen minutes, maybe.

"Because—" Aurelian started. He stopped. He looked at the sky. "Because I wanted—"

And there it was. The crack. The place where the corruption had not yet completely replaced the actual reason with its own. The place where a man who missed his home had built his home's sky over a city he had come to find interesting, and the reason was not the corruption's reason but his own.

"You wanted to show someone," Kael said softly. "That's your sky. And you're showing it to this city. Because you like this city."

The red in Aurelian's eyes was not absolute.

It was flickering.

"By the power of Voxt," Kael said.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

By the Power of Voxt



The wave came.

The thrust of displaced energy that moved outward from Kael's body in all directions simultaneously, the specific rapid shockwave that was the Voxt State announcing itself. It moved through the amber-gold false reality the way a stone moves through standing water — not destroying it, but causing it to ripple, to remember that it was constructed, to feel for a moment the edge of itself.

And from Kael's body, rising and spreading outward into the amber sky above Midway City, the ten predecessors emerged.

They were visible above the city. Aurelian saw them — all of them, each distinct, the long procession of the bloodline extending from the Eleventh Voxt in concentric forms of green-violet light. Aeron Vaultis the builder. The Second and Third. Lady Nyxora, largest and brightest, her arms in the pose of the Shrine. The four brothers — Draven, Sorek, Cael, and Miran — moving with the energy of people who know what a corrupted power looks like and what it takes to address it. The Ninth. The grandfather-Voxt.

Ten presences, visible to every eye that looked up.

The amber sky of Sorveth and the green-violet light of ten Voxt ancestors, occupying the same sky above Midway City.

Aurelian hovered and looked at them and his eyes were red and amber simultaneously and the expression on his face was the expression of someone having a very large and very important argument with themselves that they are losing on both sides.

Kael flew to him. Not fast. Not as a combatant.

As a person, moving toward another person.

He stopped directly in front of Aurelian, close enough that there was no distance between them that required combat. Close enough to be simply two people in a sky.

"I am going to try something," he said. "It will not hurt you. It will not harm you. I need you to trust me."

The red in Aurelian's eyes flickered. Flickered.

"I don't know," Aurelian said, "if I am currently someone who—"

"You are," Kael said. "You are exactly that person. You have been that person on seventeen worlds. You have been that person in an art class in Caldwell District on Tuesday evenings. You are that person right now."

The red flickered again.

Kael extended both hands. Not as weapon-arms, not in the combat sense. Open. Offered.

The same gesture as the fourth brother in the Shrine. The one who had continued the line. The one who stood with arms slightly out from his sides and palms open, the posture of someone who has decided to receive whatever comes next.

Aurelian looked at the open hands.

He looked at the ten predecessors surrounding Kael above the amber-gold city.

He looked at the sky he had built — his home's sky, the amber and the gold and the copper — and for a moment it was not a corruption and not a weapon but exactly what it was: a man painting home from memory because home was the thing behind every thing.

He reached out and took Kael's hands.

CHAPTER TWENTY

What Kael Saw



What he saw, when the Conjuring reached into Aurelian's power — when the Vost's clear signal moved through the contact of their hands into the place where the corruption lived — was not what he expected.

He had expected resistance. He had fought Malzareth at scale, had pushed back against the vast red presence with the full weight of eleven generations. He had expected something like that: enormous, consuming, requiring everything he had.

What he found was smaller.

Not weaker. Smaller. The corruption in Aurelian was not a siege — it was a thread. Very old, very patient, very deeply woven into the construction ability, but a thread. Malzareth's method was not force. It was the patient introduction of a single assumption — a single feeling of certainty — and the trust that the individual it was introduced to would do the rest themselves.

The corruption was a false foundation. And what you do with a false foundation is not demolish it. What you do is find the load-bearing point of the truth underneath it.

Kael found it.

The truth underneath Aurelian Voss's corruption was not complicated. It was this: a man who had spent twelve years protecting other people's worlds had, in a moment of transition, been given the feeling of absolute clarity about where to go next and what to

do next, and the feeling was so similar to the genuine clarity of genuine purpose that he had not noticed it was not his own.

The truth underneath was that the genuine purpose was still there. Had always been there. Was still the actual architecture of who he was — the curiosity, the care for the systems and the worlds, the ability to see what needed protecting and to build toward it. Malzareth had not replaced any of that. He had redirected it.

Kael did not fight the corruption.

He Conjured the truth.

He found the genuine purpose — the real foundation — and he asked it to reassert itself. Not as a command. As the same kind of offer he had made to the Weave Ring, to the destruction sphere, to every system he had ever Conjured into cooperation: this is what you are, at your root. This is what you want to be doing. Remember.

The corruption did not fight it. It was a thread, and the thread, held against the genuine architecture it had been grafted onto, simply did not hold.

Kael felt it go.

Not gradually, not in stages. Completely, the way a false note resolves when the right note sounds. The thread of Malzareth's certainty left the space it had occupied and what was in that space was Aurelian Voss, whole, in every dimension, without subtraction.

The orange-gold light in their joined hands went from amber-red to pure amber-gold.

Warm. Clean. His own.

Kael released his hands.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Conjuring



Aurelian Voss stood in the sky above Midway City and looked at his hands.

The orange-gold was very bright — brighter than it had been before the corruption, or perhaps simply cleaner, the specific quality of something that has been present for a long time and has just been polished. His fingers were warm all the way to the tips. No red. Not anywhere.

He looked at the city below.

The false reality was still there — the amber sky, the Sorveth-tinted surfaces, the redirected screens. He had built it in fifteen minutes with the corrupt purpose as his direction. It would take considerably less than that to take it back.

He looked at Kael.

"May I?" he said.

"Please," Kael said.

Aurelian Voss closed his eyes.

He reached into the false reality he had built and he asked it, in the same way Kael asked things — with the specific quality of attention that sees the true nature of a system and addresses it at its root — to remember what it was supposed to be. Not Sorveth's sky. Not a vector. Just air. Just Midway City's specific grey-autumn-orange night sky, with the clouds Midway City's clouds do when the weather is between seasons.

The false reality dissolved.

Not dramatically. Not in an explosion. It dissolved the way a well-constructed thing resolves when its purpose is complete: smoothly, completely, without residue. The amber sky cleared. The Sorveth-tinted surfaces returned to their ordinary Midway City colors. The screens went back to whatever they had been showing before all of this started, which in most cases was late-night programming that had been looking forward to being watched and was relieved to have the opportunity.

The clouds above the city were still there — the ones Aurelian had summoned at the start, the orange-gold lightning ones. He reached up and addressed those too, and the clouds thinned and moved and dispersed, and above Midway City the November sky was what it was: dark, partially cleared, with the city's light hitting the remaining cloud cover and making it orange in the ordinary, non-cosmic way that city light always does.

On the ground, people looked up. Then looked at each other. Then, with the specific Midway City quality of people who have just had something unusual happen and are assessing whether to talk about it or simply file it and move on, mostly filed it and moved on.

Aurelian opened his eyes.

"How does the city look?" he asked.

"Like itself," Kael said. "Like the best version of itself."

Aurelian looked down at it for a long moment.

"I am," he said, carefully, "quite angry at the Crimson Soul King."

"That's reasonable," Kael said. "He's had that effect on a lot of people."

"How do you not feel—" Aurelian stopped. He looked at Kael. "You lost your mother to his war. Your father was injured. You have been fighting something this enormous since you were born, essentially."

"I had help," Kael said. "Ten generations of it." He looked up at the sky, where the predecessor-spirits had receded but were present, always present, in the deep warm register of his awareness. "And I'm getting more."

They descended together, slowly, to the Caldwell District street below. The intersection was empty — the people who had been there at the start of all of this had dispersed during the confusion, which was probably for the best. The broken glass and the charged air were the only evidence of what had happened.

Kael looked at the street.

He looked at Aurelian.

He extended his hand.

"There is a city here that needs protecting," he said. "There is also a world out there — four planets, connected by rings, with a living star at the center — that is going to need protecting again, because the Three Siblings are still out there and the Crimson Soul King is still contained but not finished." He paused. "I could use someone who can conjure things into reality, control weather, build false realities, and dress significantly better than me."

Aurelian looked at the extended hand.

"I have a liaison to call," he said. "And a council to brief. And—" He straightened his jacket. "Considerable apologies to make, I suspect, for the business with the weather."

"Thursday coffee," Kael said. "Eight AM. Archer and Fifth. Coffee cart run by a man named Reeves who has strong opinions about decaf."

"I will be there," Aurelian said.

He took the hand.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Two Heroes



The next morning Midway City woke up and the forums had a new thread.

The thread was titled, with the economy of internet naming conventions: THERE ARE TWO OF THEM NOW.

The evidence was the surveillance footage from eleven cameras across the Caldwell District, the expressway interchange, the canal, and the warehouse district, all of which had captured the same event from different angles: two aerial figures, one green-lit and one orange-gold, moving across the city's night sky at speeds that the camera sensors had struggled to resolve. The footage was grainy and dramatic and, in several instances, genuinely beautiful — the canal camera in particular had caught the moment when Aurelian's Sorveth sky was over the city and Kael's predecessor-spirits were visible in it, and the image of eleven points of light above a city whose water was reflecting amber and green simultaneously was the kind of image that became a poster.

It was, in fact, made into a poster within seventy-two hours. This would have surprised Kael more if he had been paying more attention to the internet, which he was not, because he was busy.

The morning after the battle, he went to the coffee cart at eight AM and found Davan already there.

"I watched it from the studio roof," Davan said, without preamble. "All of it. Or as much as I could see from that angle, which was most of the canal section."

"And?"

"And," Davan said, "I need to update the documentation significantly." He had his notebook. "Also the man in the charcoal suit. Is he—"

"Coming to coffee Thursday."

"Right." Davan made a note. "Is he—"

"An ally. Yes. It's complicated and I'll explain everything. Not at the cart."

"Understood." Davan closed the notebook. "How are you?"

Kael thought about it. He thought about his ribs, which were bruised but not cracked this time, a significant improvement. He thought about the city below him when the Sorveth sky was clearing and it was becoming itself again, ordinary and specific and his. He thought about Aurelian's hands in his and the moment the corruption had resolved, the specific clean quality of something returning to what it actually was.

"Good," he said. "I'm actually good."

"Good enough to come to class tonight? Marguerite has been asking."

"Yes," he said. He meant it.



Detective Pryce called at ten.

"The official position," she said, "is currently: unexplained aerial phenomena, under review. I have bought you approximately ten days before the federal agencies stop reviewing and start acting. Use them."

"What do I do with ten days?"

"The same thing you have been doing. Be visible, be useful, be the thing this city calls it by name and means it positively." A pause. "And if you are in contact with the second aerial entity — the orange-gold one — you should probably have a conversation about what the institutional relationship with the city is going to look like going forward."

"We'll figure it out," Kael said.

"I know," said Detective Pryce. "That's why I called you and not anyone else."

She hung up.



Aurelian came to Thursday coffee in a suit the color of dark amber. He and Reeves had a long conversation about the nature of the oat milk situation that ended with Reeves making him something that he had, apparently, never made before and that Aurelian described afterward as "genuinely the best thing I have had to drink in the last four months of traveling."

This made Reeves's Thursday.

They sat at the narrow counter — Kael, Aurelian, Davan, Detective Pryce, and Seraphyne, who had been introduced as a security consultant and who had assessed Detective Pryce in thirty seconds and arrived at the same conclusion as Pryce had arrived at about the Vext: asset rather than liability — and they talked. About the city. About what it needed. About the federal agencies and the institutional relationship and the patrol patterns and the things Davan had been documenting.

And about Aetherion. About the Three Siblings still regrouping. About Malzareth, pushed back but patient. About the original agreement — the Soul Emperors and

Earth's mystical powers and the promise made before the First Voxt was chosen: protect Earth, protect the stars.

"What are you thinking?" Davan asked Aurelian, watching him listen.

"I am thinking," Aurelian said, "that I have been to seventeen worlds in six months and this is the first one where I feel like something is genuinely at stake." He looked at the coffee cart, the canal beyond it, the city going about its ordinary extraordinary business.

"That is the thing about Earth. It is so — alive. In the way that places are alive when people care about them hard enough."

"Midway City specifically," Kael said.

"Midway City specifically," Aurelian agreed. "Though I suspect this is true of all of them."

He turned his coffee cup in his hands. The orange-gold warmth at his fingertips was very clear in the morning light. Clean and his own and nothing else.

"I would like to stay," he said. "If that is agreeable."

"More than agreeable," Kael said.

Davan opened his documentation notebook. He wrote at the top of a new page: Two heroes. Then closed it.

Reeves watched all of them from behind his cart with the expression of a man who has been running a coffee cart on this corner for decades and has seen many things and has learned to take the long view.

"Same time next week?" he said.

"Same time next week," Kael said.

EPILOGUE

What Comes Next

Midway City — One Week Later



He painted it on a Saturday.

He had been planning the canvas for days — sketching it in the margins of the sketchbooks, working out the composition on the roof at two AM while the city hummed below him. He knew what he wanted: not a battle piece, not a cosmic scene, not the four planets or the Weave Rings or the Vayrune Core. Those paintings were in progress, on other canvases, for other days.

This one was the city.

Midway City from above, at dawn, the specific quality of the light when it first hits the canal and the towers and the particular geometry of the Caldwell District streets — the view he had been learning for five weeks with a body that knew how to be in the sky. Not the grid of it. The life of it: the canal running silver and orange, the rooftops where people kept improbable dogs and held improbable conversations, the coffee cart at the corner where Reeves was already setting up with the conviction of a man whose cart was permanent in a way that cities themselves were not.

He painted for four hours without stopping.

When he stopped, Davan was sitting in the corner of the studio, which had been Kael's studio exclusively for four years and was now, by gradual and mutually agreeable extension, also where Davan came to think. He was reading through his documentation notebook.

"Is it done?" Davan asked.

"I think so." Kael looked at the canvas. The city in the early light. The sense of it — the aliveness Aurelian had named, the hard caring that made a city real. "Actually, yes. It's done."

"It's the best thing you've ever painted," Davan said. He had not yet looked at it. He said this the way Davan said things he was certain of: directly, without ceremony.

"You haven't seen it yet."

"I know what you look like when you've painted something that worked," Davan said.

"You have that face."

Kael looked at the painting.

He thought about Thaerion, recovering in a Lyxaran medical facility, reading the comm reports Kael sent him every week. He thought about Elyra, acting queen of Elysiar, managing four planets with the same equanimity she managed everything. He thought about Nyxora's statue on the plateau, warm and present.

He thought about Aurelian, who was currently across the city doing a very thorough survey of every district's structural vulnerabilities and air traffic patterns and who had, on Wednesday, revealed that his ability to conjure weather included the ability to give any district in the city a better-quality autumn afternoon than it had been having, which he was deploying selectively and with restraint but definitely deploying.

He thought about Detective Pryce's ten-day window.

He thought about the Crimson Soul King, compressed but patient.

He thought about the Three Siblings, somewhere regrouping.

He thought about the original agreement. Earth and the stars. Both.

His hands were warm. The predecessor-souls at the deep register of his awareness: ten of them, patient and present, warming his palms the way they always warmed his palms.

"What do we do next?" Davan asked. He had put down the notebook.

"I have no idea," Kael said. "Something will happen. It always does."

"And when it does?"

Kael picked up his brush.

"We'll be ready," he said.

He started a new canvas.

Outside, Midway City continued.

Ordinary and extraordinary simultaneously, the way cities always are when someone is paying the right kind of attention.



End of Book Two

The Vext Chronicles continue in Book Three: Aeron Vaultis.

A NOTE ON THE CHRONICLES

The Voxt Chronicles is a series built across multiple volumes, each illuminating a distinct chapter of the bloodline that began with Aeron Vaultis and, so far, has culminated in Kael Veyrin — the Eleventh Voxt, the painter, the fulfillment of a prophecy four centuries in the making.

Aurelian Voss — whose full name, in the language of Sorveth, carries a meaning that translates approximately as one who makes real what is not yet real — will continue in the Chronicles. His story and Kael's story are, it turns out, more intertwined than either of them knew when they met at an art class on a Tuesday in Caldwell District.

Future volumes:

Book Three: Aeron Vaultis — The First Voxt. The beginning.

Book Four: Lady Nyxora — The greatest. The painter who came before.

Book Five: The Four Brothers — Draven, Sorek, Cael, and Miran. Their war. Their cost.

Each volume stands on its own. Each is necessary to the whole.



— Jason Musyoki